A Systematic Literature Review of Large Language Models and Small Language Models in Hybrid, Multi-Agent, and Monolithic Architectures

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Abstract. Large language models (LLMs) now define the state of the art in many reasoning, generation, and decision-support tasks, but their deployment cost, energy demand, latency, and hardware requirements remain substantial. Small language models (SLMs) provide an attractive alternative for edge deployment, privacy-sensitive settings, and task-specific optimisation, yet their capabilities are uneven across domains. This paper presents a systematic literature review of 54 studies on LLMs, SLMs, and SLM–LLM collaboration, with emphasis on hybrid, multi-agent, retrieval-centered, and monolithic architectures. The review is guided by four research questions addressing comparative performance, computational efficiency, orchestration mechanisms, and domain suitability. Using a PRISMA 2020-guided review design and a Web of Science-centered search process, we synthesize evidence on model choices, architectural patterns, datasets, metrics, baselines, latency, cost, energy, and reported limitations. The reanalysis of the corpus shows a strong shift toward hybrid and multi-agent designs together with a clear reporting asymmetry in which accuracy is common but cost and energy are rarely quantified. The findings indicate that SLMs are most competitive when they are paired with routing, retrieval, planning, or fusion mechanisms and when the problem space is narrow, structured, or domain-specific.

Keywords: systematic literature review · large language models · small language models · hybrid architectures · multi-agent systems · edge-cloud inference

1 Introduction

Large language models (LLMs) excel at reasoning, coding, and multimodal tasks [1, 2, 3]. However, due to the high hardware requirements (RAM, GPU, etc.) they demand, these models are usually run only on cloud-based infrastructures or very advanced local systems [4, 5]. This creates a significant bottleneck for system developers seeking to reduce cloud dependency, ensure data privacy, and avoid high operational costs [6, 7].

As a result of these limitations, small language models (SLMs) are emerging as a strong alternative. Their ability to run on local machines provides a significant advantage in terms of data security and deployment autonomy, while also offering substantially lower operational costs than cloud-scale LLM setups [6, 7]. Moreover, recent studies show that SLMs can be adapted to specific domains via fine-tuning or distillation, enabling competitive performance in specialized tasks [8, 9, 10]. In practical systems, SLMs are also attractive because they integrate well with explicit control modules (e.g., rule-based filters, routing/verification thresholds, or planners), improving controllability and reliability beyond prompt-only solutions [5, 7, 11]. However, SLMs still struggle to match the broad expertise and robust reasoning of massive frontier models, especially on tasks requiring deep contextual understanding and extensive world knowledge [3, 12]. Therefore, framing the problem as a simple "SLM-versus-LLM" competition is no longer sufficient; instead, current research investigates when a single SLM is adequate, when an LLM is necessary, and when hybrid or agent-based architectures are preferable [13, 14, 15].

The existing literature provides concrete, domain-specific examples showing that the choice between SLMs, LLMs, and hybrid designs is primarily a systems decision. In telecommunications, Symbiotic Agents reports up to a fivefold reduction in decision error and near-real-time operation (82 ms loops) with up to 99.9% lower GPU overhead using SLM variants [16]. In medicine, self-reflective pipelines pair a compact generator with an LLM-based judge to iteratively refine outputs and improve diagnostic reliability [17].

These developments provide practical alternatives for scenarios where relying on a single monolithic LLM is either insufficient for task demands or impractical under strict resource constraints. Accordingly, recent work increasingly targets measurable improvements beyond raw accuracy, including reduced computational load, lower operational cost, and tighter latency budgets [4,5,13,16]. Across domains, researchers have reported which hybrid design patterns are effective for specific task classes—for example, selective edge–cloud verification, expert routing, and retrieval- or planner-centered pipelines—and how these choices translate to real-world deployments [11, 13, 18, 19].

Motivated by these trends, this review analyzes when a single SLM is sufficient, when an LLM remains necessary, and when hybrid or multi-agent architectures provide the best trade-off between capability and efficiency. We further examine domain conditions under which fine-tuned SLMs can realistically replace or complement larger models, and where they still fall short, synthesizing recurring architectural motifs across telecom, medical, and cybersecurity settings.

The main contributions of this review are as follows: (1) It provides a synthesized overview of 54 studies covering cloud-based monolithic LLMs, hybrid SLM–LLM architectures, the performance of fine-tuned SLMs versus large models, and multi-agent workflows. (2) It reframes the literature around four distinct practical research questions: Performance, Efficiency, Architecture, and Domain Suitability. (3) It creates an analytical review matrix that reveals the commonalities and differences among the studies, mapping which specific research question each study addresses.

Section	Key Elements
Review focus	SLR: Hybrid & SLM Systems
Motivation (Intro)	LLM constraints: cost, latency, privacy; SLM opportunities: local, adaptable, controllable; system view: hybrid, routing, and agent-based designs
Corpus & Method	PRISMA + selection; data extraction (54 studies); taxonomy and labels defined in this review
Models / Architectural Families	Single SLM (local/on-device); Hybrid SLM+LLM (edge–cloud); Multi-agent systems; RAG-centric pipelines; Control and routing modules
RQ1: Performance	Hybrid SLM+LLM (draft–verify); Multi-agent collaboration; Self-reflective or judge-in-the-loop pipelines
RQ2: Efficiency	Latency, VRAM, and cost proxies; Energy or energy-per-token; Edge feasibility
RQ3: Architecture	RAG + rerank or long-context support; Planner or adaptive retrieval; Expert routing or orchestration
RQ4: Domain suitability	Fine-tuned SLMs or domain fusion; Privacy-sensitive local domains; Where SLMs fall short (reasoning gap)
Contributions	(1) 54-study synthesis; (2) RQ framing; (3) Review matrix

Fig. 1. Overview of the review structure and taxonomy used in this SLR (synthesized from the reviewed corpus).

2 Related Works

Prior review literature on Small Language Models (SLMs) and SLM–LLM collaboration can be grouped into four highly relevant works that overlap with our scope at different levels of methodology and emphasis. The closest methodological competitor is a recent PRISMA 2020-guided SLR that sources studies from multiple databases and provides a reproducible selection protocol [20]. While strong in transparency, it adopts a broader topical scope (SLMs in general), and its coverage window ends around early 2025, limiting visibility into the 2025–2026 wave of hybrid and agent-based systems.

The remaining three works are narrative surveys with substantial thematic overlap. One study provides wide coverage of SLM definitions, training techniques, applications, collaboration with LLMs, and trustworthiness, but does not follow a systematic and reproducible selection protocol [21]. Another presents a technically detailed taxonomy of collaboration patterns (e.g., routing, auxiliary modules, fusion, and distillation) with an emphasis on edge-device requirements, yet its analysis is primarily mechanism-centered rather than corpus-centered [22]. A further work overlaps strongly with our themes (performance, cost, privacy, and trustworthiness) but remains a narrative survey without a formal PRISMA-guided study selection and extraction schema [23].

Across these reviews, the gap is not a lack of attention to SLMs or collaboration, but a difference in analytical emphasis and evidential grounding. Existing surveys typically describe what kinds of models or mechanisms exist; however, they rarely align empirical evidence across domains or report comparable operational metrics. In contrast, our study is positioned as a PRISMA-guided, engineering-oriented synthesis that (i) treats domain suitability as a first-class axis, (ii) maps research questions to structured extraction fields to ensure traceability, and (iii) emphasizes quantitative indicators (accuracy, latency, cost, and energy) to support deployment-relevant decision-making.

3 Research Methodology

3.1 Information Sources and Search Strategy

To capture a comprehensive and high-quality corpus of contemporary AI architectures, the literature search was conducted utilizing the Web of Science (WoS) Core Collection. Utilizing WoS as the primary search engine allowed for the retrieval of indexed peer-reviewed journal articles, conference proceedings, and highly cited preprints within a single dataset. The search timeframe was restricted to publications between 2023 and 2026 to reflect the rapid, recent emergence of small and agentic language models.

The search strategy was designed to capture the intersection of model size, architectural design, and system evaluation. The following Boolean query was applied to the title, abstract, and keyword fields:

> ("Large Language Model*" OR "LLM" OR "Generative AI" OR "Foundation Model*") AND ("Small Language Model*" OR "SLM" OR "Compact Model*" OR "Lightweight Model*" OR "TinyLlama" OR "Phi-3" OR "Mistral" OR "Qwen") AND ("Multi-agent" OR "Hybrid" OR "Orchestration" OR "Routing" OR "Ensemble" OR "Agentic") AND ("Performance" OR "Accuracy" OR "Efficiency" OR "Latency" OR "Cost" OR "Benchmark")

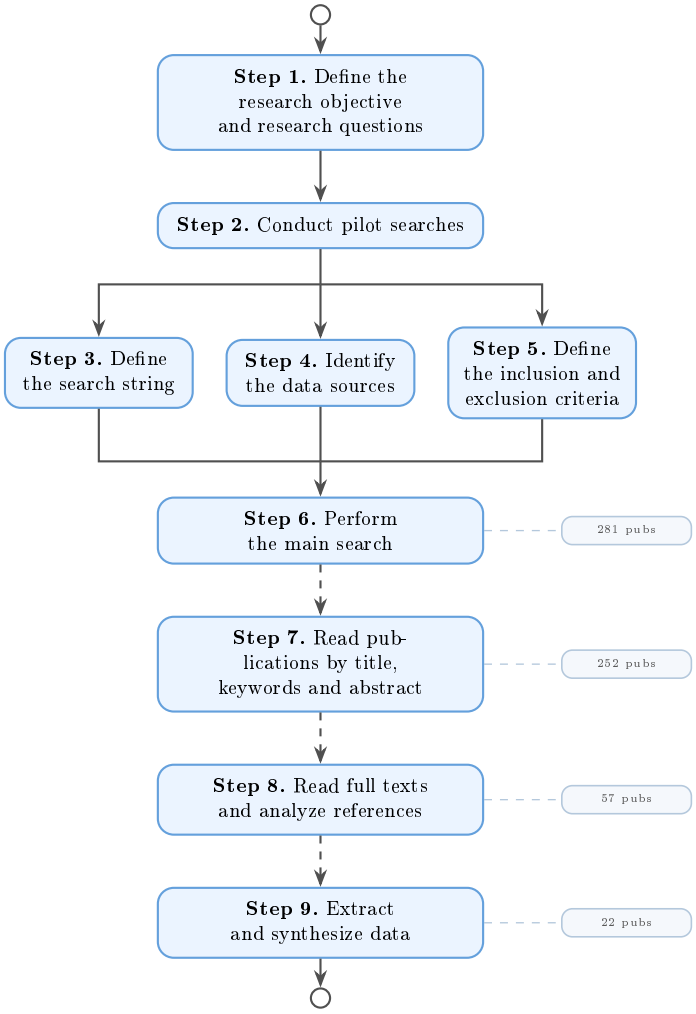

Fig. 2. Systematic literature review process

3.2 Eligibility Criteria

To systematically isolate systems-level engineering research from the broader generative AI literature, retrieved records were evaluated against strict eligibility criteria. A comprehensive breakdown of the inclusion and exclusion parameters applied during the screening phases is presented in Table 1.

Table 1. Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria for Study Selection

Criteria	Inclusion (Include if...)	Exclusion (Exclude if...)
Architecture Scope	Studies evaluating SLMs alone or SLM and LLM collaborative architectures (e.g., Hybrid or Multi-agent).	Studies strictly comparing massive monolithic LLMs (e.g., GPT-4 vs. Gemini) without an SLM component.
Model Size	Architectures involving "small" models that strictly adhere to a parameter count of ≤ 7 Billion.	"Closed-box" or API-bound models where parameter count or architectural details are undisclosed (violates reproducibility).
Topic Focus	Focuses on quantitative system-level metrics such as performance, inference latency, memory, cost, or orchestration efficiency.	Focuses solely on ethical, sociological impacts, or legal regulations without technical benchmarks.
Data Quality	Contains empirical results and experimental validation (e.g., standard benchmarks or custom datasets).	Purely theoretical papers or non-empirical narrative surveys.
Timeframe	Published between 2023 and 2026 (capturing the recent emergence of SLM/Agentic architectures).	Published before 2023.

3.3 Study Selection Process

The study selection process adhered to the PRISMA 2020 guidelines [24]. The initial literature search yielded 116 records. Because the export was generated from a single, centralized database engine (Web of Science), zero duplicate records required manual removal. The progression of the screening process is illustrated in Figure 2.

The screening was conducted in two distinct phases to ensure methodological rigor. During the initial Title and Abstract screening, 22 records were excluded for lacking general relevance to the architectural scope. These exclusions primarily consisted of non-empirical narrative surveys, hardware scheduling studies lacking architectural orchestration, and studies operating in entirely separate domains (e.g., computer vision or 3D hand gesture recognition).

The remaining 94 records advanced to a rigorous Full-Text review. During this phase, an additional 40 studies were excluded after deeply evaluating their methodologies against the technical constraints. Exclusions at this stage occurred when the evaluated "small" models exceeded the strict

$\leq$ 7B parameter threshold, the evaluations relied on closed-box APIs that hindered reproducibility, or the methodologies failed to report quantitative system-level performance metrics.

To mitigate selection bias during both screening phases, a team consensus mechanism was utilized. Inclusion and exclusion decisions were made via majority vote among the reviewing authors. In the event of a tie, the conflict was resolved through collaborative discussion and escalation to the academic advisors. Following this two-stage screening process, a final corpus of 54 primary studies was established for data extraction and synthesis.

3.4 Data Extraction and Synthesis Strategy

To systematically address the research questions, a standardized data extraction protocol was applied to the final corpus of 54 primary studies. For each study, data was extracted into a structured matrix to capture both the functional design of the systems and the empirical evidence used to justify them.

The extracted fields included the specific SLM and LLM models utilized, the overarching architecture type (e.g., Hybrid, Multi-Agent, RAG, Ensemble), orchestration mechanisms, evaluation metrics, baseline models, and quantitative performance indicators (accuracy, latency, cost, and energy). To ensure analytical rigor, each extracted variable was explicitly mapped to one or more of the core Research Questions (RQs). This mapping is detailed in Table 2.

Table 2. RQ $\times$ data extraction matrix used in the review. A check mark indicates that the field directly supports the corresponding research question.

Extraction Field	RQ1	RQ2	RQ3	RQ4
Models Used (SLM)	✓			✓
Models Used (LLM)	✓			✓
Architecture	✓			✓
Orchestration Method			✓	✓
Agent Count		✓		✓
Task Type	✓		✓	
Dataset	✓		✓	
Metrics	✓		✓	✓
LLM Baseline	✓		✓	✓
SLM Baseline	✓		✓	✓
Accuracy	✓		✓	
Latency (ms)		✓	✓	✓
Cost ($)		✓	✓	✓
Energy		✓	✓	✓
Key Findings	✓	✓	✓	✓
Limitations		✓	✓	

Following data extraction, a narrative synthesis approach was utilized. Because the included studies operate across diverse domains (e.g., telecommunications, healthcare, software engineering) and report varying metrics, a purely statistical meta-analysis was not feasible. Instead, studies were grouped by their architectural taxonomy, allowing for a comparative analysis of how different orchestration methods and domain constraints impact the performance and efficiency trade-offs between large and small models.

4 Summary of the Studies

Before detailing the specific findings related to the research questions, this section provides a structural overview of the 54 primary studies included in this review. During the data extraction phase, 16 key characteristics were systematically captured for each study to facilitate comparative analysis. Each extraction field is defined below:

- **Study ID:** A unique identifier (S1–S54) assigned to each study for streamlined referencing throughout the text and appendix.
- **Year:** Indicates the year the study was formally published or released as a preprint.
- **SLM(s):** Lists the specific small language model(s) evaluated, fine-tuned, or deployed within the proposed system.
- **LLM(s):** Specifies the large language model(s) utilized either as a performance baseline, a teacher for distillation, or a cloud-based fallback.
- **Architecture (Arch.):** Describes the overarching structural design of the system, such as hybrid edge-cloud, multi-agent ensemble, or retrieval-augmented generation.
- **Orchestration Method:** Specifies the exact mechanism used to coordinate models and tasks, such as token-level routing, prompt-guided fusion, or majority voting.
- **Agent Count:** Indicates the number of distinct agents, roles, or expert models operating within the proposed system.
- **Task Type:** Details the specific downstream application, domain, or computational problem evaluated in the study.
- **Dataset:** Identifies the specific benchmarks, open-source datasets, or proprietary clinical/industrial data used to train and evaluate the system.
- **Metrics:** Outlines the primary evaluation criteria used to assess model performance, efficiency, and resource consumption.
- **LLM Baseline:** Reports the baseline performance score of the standalone large language model.
- **SLM Baseline:** Reports the baseline performance score of the standalone small language model.
- **Accuracy:** Presents the final performance or accuracy metric achieved by the proposed hybrid or SLM-centered architecture.
- **Latency (ms):** Captures the inference speed, time-to-first-token, or overall time delay reported by the authors.
- **Cost ($):** Highlights any reported financial savings regarding API usage or computational reductions relative to full LLM inference.
- **Energy:** Details power consumption, Joules-per-token, or carbon footprint implications, if measured by the authors.
- **Key Findings:** Summarizes the core takeaway and primary contribution of the study regarding SLM-LLM orchestration.
- **Limitations:** Highlights the constraints, failure modes, data dependencies, or hardware bottlenecks identified by the authors.

Because the full comparative analysis table is located in the online appendix, the mapping of Study IDs to their respective bibliographic citations is provided below for quick reference:

Primary Studies Mapping: S1: [6], S2: [13], S3: [8], S4: [19], S5: [25], S6: [18], S7: [26], S8: [7], S9: [27], S10: [11], S11: [28], S12: [12], S13: [29], S14: [30], S15: [31], S16: [32], S17: [17], S18: [33], S19: [34], S20: [35], S21: [36], S22: [37], S23: [38], S24: [39], S25: [40], S26: [41], S27: [15], S28: [42],

S29: [43], S30: [19], S31: [44], S32: [10], S33: [45], S34: [4], S35: [46], S36: [47], S37: [48], S38: [49], S39: [50], S40: [51], S41: [1], S42: [2], S43: [9], S44: [52], S45: [53], S46: [54], S47: [55], S48: [5], S49: [3], S50: [56], S51: [57], S52: [58], S53: [14], S54: [59].

The comprehensive data extraction spreadsheet can be accessed at: https://bit.ly/SLM-LLM-Data-2026.

5 Findings

5.1 Corpus-Level Trends Before the RQ Analysis

Before answering the four research questions directly, three corpus-level observations are worth emphasizing.

First, the field is now primarily a systems literature rather than a pure model-scaling literature. Although a few studies still compare standalone small and large models directly, the dominant trend is to embed them inside a larger control strategy. Hybrid edge-cloud pipelines, retrieval-centered systems, expert routers, task decomposers, self-reflective workflows, and fusion modules are now common design choices. In other words, recent work increasingly treats model scale as one variable in a broader systems problem.

Second, hybridization is motivated by different constraints in different domains. In telecom and networking, the main concerns are deployment, context fidelity, and latency budgets. In healthcare and scientific tasks, the dominant concerns are reliability, interpretability, and domain specificity. In industrial monitoring, multimodal hybridization is driven by the need to combine coarse global understanding with fine-grained local detail. In optimisation and education, hybrid methods often serve as a way to recover reasoning quality from small models through feedback, routing, or targeted prompting.

Third, the evidence base is uneven. Accuracy is almost always reported; compute, latency, and cost are not. This matters because a large share of the literature frames hybridization as an efficiency solution, yet only a minority of studies expose sufficiently comparable numbers to test those claims rigorously. The result is a literature that often proves that hybridization *can* work, but less often proves how much it costs in practice under standardized conditions.

5.2 RQ1: Comparative Performance of Hybrid and Multi-Agent Systems

The reviewed evidence shows that both hybrid and multi-agent architectures can outperform standalone small-model baselines, but their advantages emerge through different forms of coordination rather than parameter scaling alone. Hybrid systems achieve their strongest gains when computation is selectively distributed between local small models and stronger remote models. Token-level edge–cloud collaboration improves small-model performance without requiring full-query escalation: one study reports LLM-comparable quality on GSM8K at only 25.8% of full-cloud cost by using TinyLlama 1.1B or Llama-2-7B as edge-side drafting models and Llama-2-70B as a cloud verifier (S2). Similarly, routing only about 7% of low-confidence tokens from a 0.5B on-device model to a cloud-hosted Qwen2.5-32B-Instruct model yields over 60% performance improvement over the local-only setup while preserving more than 80% cost reduction relative to full LLM inference (S46). This pattern is reinforced by uncertainty-aware hybrid inference, where opportunistic skipping reduces uplink transmissions and LLM computations by 45.93%, reaches up to 97.54% of LLM inference accuracy, and delivers 2.54× faster token throughput than hybrid inference without skipping (S45).

At the sub-task level, structured task decomposition and cloud–edge allocation reduce average reasoning time by 66.12% and API cost by 83.57% while maintaining reasoning accuracy comparable to the best baselines (S53). In domain-specific settings, hybrid orchestration can also outperform larger general-purpose models: a fine-tuned Phi-2 (2.7B) combined with retrieval, reranking, hybrid search, and long-context support achieves 84.20% accuracy, exceeding GPT-4o mini (82.05%) and GPT-4o (80.80%) on telecom question answering (S4).

Multi-agent systems, by contrast, show their comparative strength when performance depends on role specialization, critique, verification, and distributed reasoning. A three-agent Phi-3-based architecture performs on par with human experts in conceptual genomics tasks, although its gains weaken on more complex code-generation workflows, indicating that multi-agent benefits remain task-sensitive (S51). In reasoning-intensive question answering, a Proponent–Opponent–Arbitrator structure built on compact models such as Qwen2.5 0.5B and DeepSeek-R1 1.5B surpasses both single-agent reasoning and vanilla LLM baselines with only 1.8× inference-time overhead (S37). Likewise, assistant–checker collaboration supported by memory and feedback loops enables small-model multi-agent systems to approach or exceed larger baselines across several tasks: LeptoConnect-7B outperforms GPT-3.5-turbo by 163.1% on database tasks, while LeptoConnect-1.8B reaches 81.6% of GPT-4's score on knowledge graph tasks, and an enhanced TinyLlama-1.8B improves ROUGE-L by 63.4% over CodeLlama-7B in code correction (S20). Overall, the findings indicate that hybrid systems are most effective when the main challenge is balancing accuracy with latency and cost through adaptive routing, whereas multi-agent systems are most effective when the task benefits from explicit decomposition of reasoning roles and iterative verification. Thus, the comparative performance advantage of both architecture families is driven primarily by orchestration strategy, not by model size alone.

5.3 RQ2: Efficiency, Cost, Latency, and Energy Trade-offs

The Appendix A data reveals that while efficiency motivates the adoption of hybrid and multi-agent systems, the actual impact on cost, latency, and energy depends heavily on the orchestration method. Hybridization is not a universal efficiency solution; it introduces a trade-off space where computational bottlenecks are often shifted rather than eliminated.

Regarding inference cost and token consumption, architectures employing selective escalation or task decomposition drastically reduce reliance on massive standalone LLMs. Study S46 achieves an over 80% cost reduction compared to full LLM inference by routing fewer than 7% of generated tokens to the cloud. Similarly, S2 uses a token-level draft-verification method to match the quality of a 70B parameter LLM while consuming only 25.8% to 31.2% of standard cloud inference costs. Query-level decomposition yields similar savings: S53 cuts average API costs by 83.57% via parallel reasoning. Computational savings are also heavily emphasized through token reduction. Study S33 achieves a 95% reduction in LLM token transmissions via federated uncertainty-aware routing, and S27 eliminates redundant multi-round communications through an SLM-generated directed acyclic graph, reducing token consumption by 35% to 70%. In dialogue state tracking, S6 highlights that a retrieval-based router reduces overall computational FLOPs by approximately 62%.

Conversely, the impact on latency is highly polarized. In optimal scenarios, relying on lightweight models accelerates throughput. A fine-tuned SLM in a hybrid classification pipeline (S32) operates at 7.41 ms on a GPU, making it over 20 times faster than its larger counterpart. Furthermore, S45 shows that uncertainty-aware skipping in an edge-cloud setup provides 2.54× faster token throughput. However, orchestration mechanisms frequently introduce new latency bottlenecks. Planners

and retrievers add non-trivial temporal overhead; the adaptive retrieval planner in S10 takes 1.42 seconds compared to 0.95 seconds for naive retrieval, and S4 explicitly identifies cross-encoder reranking as its primary latency bottleneck. Multi-agent collaboration also inherently multiplies inference cycles. Study S37 reports a 1.8× inference-time overhead for adversarial debate, and complex agentic workflows in S22 can push average response latencies to 107 seconds. Processing time is further impacted by hardware and modality constraints, such as constrained local hardware (S11), dual-path video sampling (S5), CPU-only zero-shot ensembles taking upwards of 859 seconds (S47), and multi-turn key-value cache recomputation at the edge (S48).

Energy consumption remains the least documented metric in the reviewed corpus, though the few studies that measure it provide critical systems insights. Study S16 demonstrates the resource efficiency of small models by showing that symbiotic SLM agents reduce the VRAM footprint by 99.9% while saving 44.43% of physical resource blocks in radio access networks. Memory architecture also aids efficiency; study S20 shows that a dual-scale memory system reduces computational redundancy by 26.4%, inherently lowering the energy required for repeated edge computations. However, study S34 provides a groundbreaking caveat: forcing a small model to execute complex reasoning workflows, such as Chain-of-Thought, drastically inflates its energy consumption per query. In specific contexts, querying a massive standalone LLM without Chain-of-Thought is actually more energy-efficient than forcing an SLM through a lengthy reasoning prompt. This finding underscores that smaller parameter counts do not automatically guarantee lower energy footprints if the prompting strategy artificially extends the generation length.

5.4 RQ3: Orchestration and Routing Mechanisms

The corpus contains a broad set of orchestration mechanisms, but they can be organized into a small number of recurring families. Across the included studies, performance differences are explained less by absolute model size than by how effectively the system retrieves evidence, routes uncertainty, and divides labor across components.

Token-level collaboration. Token-level orchestration is most visible in verification-oriented hybrid systems. Study S2 uses the SLM as a drafter and the LLM as a verifier on difficult tokens. Study S45 extends this pattern with uncertainty-aware skipping so that likely acceptable SLM tokens can bypass the remote model. Study S46 reaches a related design point by routing only low-confidence tokens for external inference. Taken together, these studies show that token-level collaboration provides fine-grained control over answer quality, but it can also introduce communication and synchronization overhead when escalation rates increase.

Query-level or example-level routing. Query-level routing appears when the system selects a processing path for the full input rather than for individual tokens. Study S6 exemplifies retrieval-based expert routing at the dialogue level, while Study S32 shows that instance-level model selection can also be effective in customer-review analysis. These designs are most useful when "easy" and "hard" cases can be separated in a semantically meaningful way before full generation begins.

Retrieval-centered orchestration. RAG is a major control mechanism in the corpus even when the architecture is classified as hybrid rather than purely RAG. Studies S4, S10, S31, and S44 use retrieval not only to expand context but also to constrain the action space of a smaller model. In these studies, retrieval acts as a coordination layer that narrows ambiguity, grounds the answer in domain evidence, and reduces reliance on raw model scale alone.

Planner-based decomposition and agentic workflows. Task decomposition is increasingly important in the recent corpus. Study S53 uses a task decomposer, dependency graph, and plug-and-play adapter to allocate subtasks between local and remote models. Study S52 uses a feedback-integrated workflow that gathers structured feedback from multiple perspectives before revising the prompt of the smaller model. Related role-based decomposition also appears in Study S11, Study S20, and Study S51. Across these studies, the common idea is that small models remain viable when the workflow can be partitioned into specialist stages rather than handled as a single undifferentiated generation step.

Fusion and multimodal coordination. Not all orchestration is text-only. Study S5 combines coarse-grained and fine-grained visual semantics through prompt-guided fusion, while Study S3 fuses language-model embeddings with graph-based features for molecular-property prediction. In these settings, orchestration is best understood as structured fusion across heterogeneous sources of evidence.

These patterns support a broader interpretation of orchestration. It is not merely an implementation detail added after model selection. Across the included studies, orchestration is often the main source of improvement. The strongest systems define when the SLM should act alone, when evidence should be retrieved, and when a larger model or another specialist should be involved. This helps explain why the same small model may perform weakly in monolithic form yet remain competitive when embedded in a more deliberate control architecture.

5.5 RQ4: Domain Suitability of SLM-Centered Systems

The corpus shows that SLM competitiveness is domain-dependent rather than universal. Small models are most successful when at least one of the following conditions holds: the domain vocabulary is narrow, the task is structurally constrained, domain retrieval can ground the generation process, the output is partially symbolic or template-like, or the system can escalate uncertain cases to a larger model.

Telecom and networking. Telecom is one of the clearest success stories for SLM-centered systems. Study S4 and other reviewed telecom QA studies show that small models can perform well when standards documents are retrieved effectively and the generator is trained or prompted for domain fidelity. The reasons are intuitive: the domain is terminology-heavy, the relevant documents are accessible, and faithfulness matters at least as much as broad generative flexibility.

Healthcare and scientific domains. Healthcare results are mixed rather than uniformly positive. On the one hand, the review includes strong performance in radiology report labeling (S12), chest X-ray reporting (S17), VTE identification (S26), multilingual medical summarization (S35), and molecular property prediction (S3). These are tasks with domain structure, labeled outputs, or strong contextual priors. On the other hand, the corpus also contains medical question-answering (S21, S22) and diagnosis-generation (S19) settings where larger models remain more capable or where reasoning prompts drastically inflate latency. The lesson is not that healthcare favors one model scale universally, but that smaller models work best when the output space is constrained and domain knowledge can be tightly anchored.

Reasoning, optimisation, and education. Reasoning-heavy tasks produce some of the most interesting hybrid results. Study S54 improves mathematical reasoning enough for 7B models to surpass GPT-3.5-Turbo on SVAMP. Study S52 shows that even very weak baseline SLM performance on optimisation formulation can be transformed through feedback-guided prompt evolution. Study S53 and question-answering agents demonstrate that decomposition and selective allocation can keep small models viable on reasoning workloads that would be implausible in a single-pass local-only setup. These studies suggest that small models are not inherently incapable of reasoning; rather, they are highly sensitive to scaffolding.

Code, software, and agentic tasks. The selected corpus includes several code-related or software-oriented studies, including code correction, type and call-graph analysis (S42), offline robotic decision-making (S13), and academic feedback generation (S23). These tasks often reward decomposition, specialist routing, or domain grounding more than sheer model size. Still, several reviewed systems note that performance drops as task complexity increases, especially when the agent must synthesize many steps or maintain long interaction histories.

Multimodal industrial monitoring. Study S5 illustrates a particularly important case because it is not a conventional text benchmark. In industrial video monitoring, the hybrid system outperforms both the lightweight and the larger baseline models because the task benefits from two complementary forms of attention: one to continuity and one to salient detail. This suggests that in multimodal domains, the question is often not whether the small model can replace the large one, but whether each can capture a different slice of the evidence.

Failure modes and limitations. The domain analysis also reveals several failure modes. Small models struggle most when the task requires broad open-domain knowledge, long-context synthesis without strong retrieval, or flexible reasoning over ambiguous instructions. They also become brittle when prompt structure matters too much or when coordination modules are themselves inaccurate. A central finding of the review is therefore that SLM suitability should be evaluated as a property of *system design plus domain*, not as a stable property of parameter count alone.

5.6 Cross-RQ Synthesis

Viewed together, the four research questions suggest that the literature is converging toward a specific systems principle: hybrid language-model design works best when the large model is treated as a selectively invoked capability rather than the default engine for every token, query, or subtask.

The first implication is architectural. Strong results are associated with explicit control layers such as routers, planners, retrievers, or fusion modules. This means that future progress is unlikely to come only from making SLMs slightly larger or LLMs slightly cheaper. It will also depend on better confidence estimation, task decomposition, retrieval selection, and cross-model scheduling.

The second implication is methodological. Because accuracy dominates reporting, many studies overstate practical efficiency. The corpus already contains cases where stronger orchestration clearly reduces cost or latency, but it also contains cases where coordination shifts the bottleneck rather than removing it. A mature evaluation protocol should therefore report resource metrics as first-class outcomes rather than optional extras.

The third implication is application-oriented. The most successful SLM-centered deployments are not generic substitutes for LLMs. They are domain-adapted systems in which the small model is

grounded, specialized, or protected by escalation logic. This is why telecom, structured reasoning, radiology labeling, optimisation formulation, and industrial monitoring are so prominent in the positive findings of the corpus.

6 Threats to Validity

This review has several threats to validity that should be stated explicitly.

Internal validity. Although the review follows a PRISMA-guided workflow, study identification, screening, and extraction still involve researcher judgment. Borderline papers may have been interpreted differently under another reading of the inclusion criteria, especially in cases where the SLM component or the empirical contribution was not equally central throughout the paper. The representative PDF inspection used to deepen the narrative also adds a second judgment layer, because not every included study was read in the same depth. To reduce this risk, borderline screening decisions were discussed through team consensus, and the synthesis remained tied to the predefined research questions and the same extraction matrix throughout.

Construct validity. Some of the core constructs in this review are not standardized across the literature. In particular, "SLM", "hybrid architecture", "multi-agent system", and "efficiency" are defined differently from paper to paper. A single hybrid label may refer to token-level verification, retrieval-grounded generation, planner-based decomposition, or multimodal fusion. Likewise, efficiency may mean latency, FLOPs, API cost, bandwidth reduction, or energy use. This threatens direct comparability and means that some studies grouped under the same high-level category differ substantially in mechanism. To partially limit this, the review separates broad architecture labels from extracted orchestration mechanisms and discusses recurring mechanism families explicitly.

Conclusion validity. The strongest limitation for cross-study inference is the uneven and inconsistent reporting of evaluation outcomes. Accuracy is reported in most papers, but latency, cost, and energy are available only in a minority, often with different units, hardware assumptions, or deployment settings. For that reason, the review can identify recurring patterns, but it cannot support a formal meta-analysis or strong quantitative claims about the size of efficiency gains across the whole corpus. This threat is reinforced by publication and reporting bias, since positive hybrid results are more likely to be published and summarized than negative or inconclusive findings. To partly temper this, the extraction also recorded reported limitations, and the synthesis emphasizes uneven reporting and task-sensitive trade-offs rather than universal gains.

External validity. The corpus is based on a Web of Science-centered search and a bounded review window. This improves transparency and reproducibility, but it may miss relevant studies from other databases, preprint platforms, or fast-moving venues. At the same time, WoS provides broad coverage across major peer-reviewed journals and conference proceedings in a single indexed source, which helps reduce, though not remove, this coverage risk. The field also evolves quickly, and the current corpus is heavily concentrated in 2025 and in a limited set of application domains. Therefore, the conclusions should be generalized cautiously beyond the covered time period, tasks, and deployment settings.

7 Conclusion

This paper presented a systematic literature review of 54 studies on SLMs, LLMs, and SLM–LLM collaboration across monolithic, hybrid, multi-agent, ensemble, and retrieval-centered architectures.

The review was structured around four practical questions: comparative performance, efficiency, orchestration, and domain suitability. Across these four axes, the main pattern is consistent: SLMs are most competitive when they are supported by retrieval, routing, uncertainty estimation, task decomposition, prompt optimisation, or multimodal fusion rather than used as isolated replacements for larger models.

The findings also show that the literature is stronger in architectural innovation than in evaluation discipline. Many studies report accuracy improvements, but far fewer report latency, cost, or energy in a form that supports fair comparison. As a result, the current evidence is sufficient to show that hybridization can work, but often insufficient to show when it is the better deployment choice under realistic resource constraints. The review also suggests that the strongest positive results are concentrated in narrower or more structured settings such as telecom question answering, selected healthcare tasks, optimisation, and industrial monitoring, while open-ended reasoning and broad general-purpose use remain less convincing for SLM-centered systems.

For future research, three gaps stand out. First, the field needs more standardized reporting of resource metrics, hardware assumptions, and escalation rates. In particular, more studies that directly measure energy consumption under comparable settings would be valuable. Second, it needs clearer operational definitions for SLM size ranges and architecture categories so that "hybrid" and "efficient" systems can be compared more reliably. Third, more domain-grounded evaluations are needed on failure cases, long-context behavior, orchestration overhead, and the conditions under which SLM-only, hybrid, and multi-agent designs stop scaling. In that sense, this SLR finds a literature that is already rich in system ideas, but still incomplete in measurement, comparability, and boundary-setting.

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